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The Editors
BMC Medical Informatics and Decision Making

Submission of a research article: "TRACER-Med: differentially private evidential learning with prototype alignment and conformal prediction for clinical risk prediction"

Dear Editors,

We submit the above manuscript as a research article for consideration in *BMC Medical Informatics and Decision Making*.

Why this journal. The manuscript concerns machine-learning methods for clinical decision support, which is within the scope of the journal. It evaluates a framework that combines differentially private training, a fairness-oriented alignment term, private conformal calibration, and uncertainty-aware attribution, on four cohorts (one real hospital cohort of 20,000 patients, two small public clinical benchmarks, and one simulated cohort), with an exact privacy accountant, a noise-multiplier sweep, ablations, and comparisons with DPSGD-F and an adaptation of PF-LD. The main findings are mixed and are reported as such: the framework gives better calibration on the larger cohorts under differential privacy, but it does not improve equalized-odds disparity relative to the private baselines, its subgroup-calibrated clipping shows no consistent benefit, and its private conformal layer is uninformative on small cohorts. The manuscript also reports a numerical audit of its analytical statements and the corrections it led to. Because the journal assesses scientific validity and not perceived impact, we believe it is a suitable venue for a study whose contribution is a carefully evaluated and fully reproducible set of results, including negative ones.

Issues relating to journal policies. All data are publicly available and de-identified, or synthetic, and no ethics approval was required. The Pima Indians Diabetes data originate from an Indigenous community, and the manuscript states the related data-governance considerations. All code, result files, and numerical checks are available, and the result files are included as additional files. The manuscript contains a statement on the use of generative AI tools.

Competing interests. The authors declare no competing interests.

Authorship and originality. All authors have approved the manuscript for submission. The authors are Quang-Vinh Dang (British University Vietnam), Dat Le (Ho Chi Minh City University of Economics and Finance), and Minh Ngoc Dinh (Millennia Education). The content has not been published and is not under consideration for publication elsewhere.

Sincerely,

On behalf of all authors,
Quang-Vinh Dang
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